

CASOGEOGRAPHICS

THE LONG GEOGRAPHY OF POLITICS

A decision brief for think tanks, political teams and territorial institutions

EXECUTIVE BRIEF

Electoral geography • GIS • Historical persistence • Neighbourhood strategy

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Version 1.0 | June 2026

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1. The decision problem

Political analysis often explains who voted and by how much, while leaving the territorial mechanisms of political behaviour underdeveloped. National polling and municipal totals can conceal the neighbourhoods where participation is collapsing, support is consolidating or a political coalition is internally heterogeneous.

Geo-Historical Political Intelligence reconnects political data with the places that produced it. It combines electoral results, GIS, historical trajectories, infrastructure, institutions and field knowledge to identify actionable territorial patterns without inferring individual political beliefs.

Core proposition

A campaign, think tank or public institution should not ask only “Which candidate performed best?” It should also ask: Where is electoral weight located? Which territorial cleavages structure competition? Which places require persuasion, mobilisation, listening or long-term institutional presence?

The approach is designed for aggregate territorial units such as polling sections, neighbourhoods, municipalities and functional zones. It supports strategic communication and resource allocation at area level, while excluding individual political profiling and discriminatory targeting.

2. The STRATA framework

STRATA: a mechanism-based framework for geo-historical political intelligence



Substrate Territorial trajectories Regimes & institutions Actors & social morphology Territorial political outputs Assessment & alternatives

Geology, relief, climate, Settlement, production, Borders, property, Demography, work, Vote, turnout, protest, Validation, counterfactuals, limits, scenarios
resources, accessibility infrastructure, migration administration, public services networks, memory policy, conflict

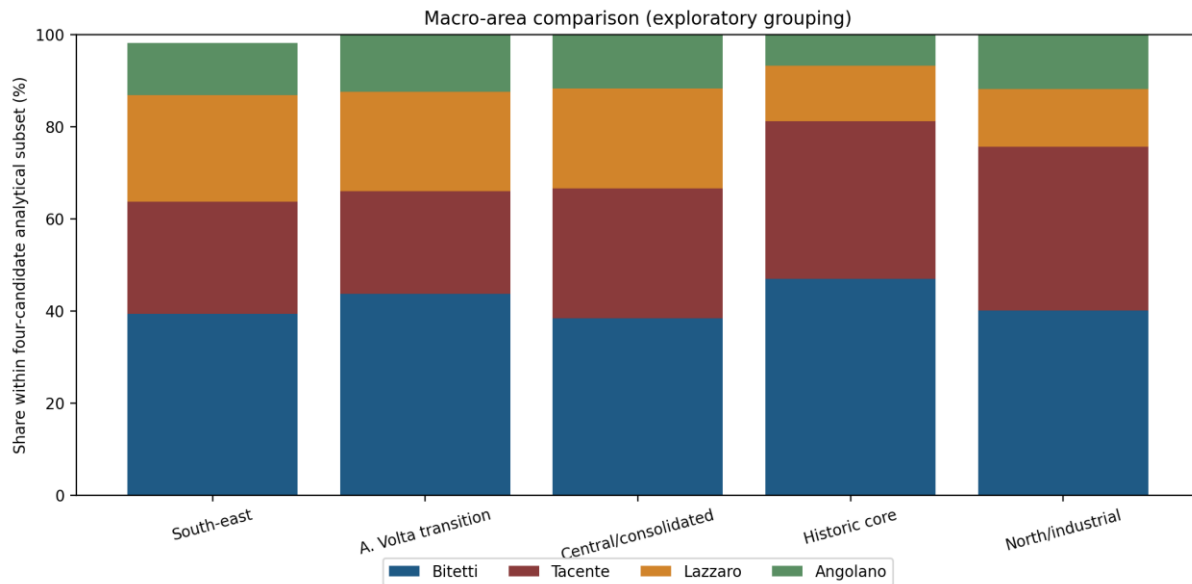
The sequence is analytical rather than deterministic: feedback loops may operate in both directions.

STRATA organises territorial political analysis into six connected analytical layers.

Layer	Question	Typical evidence
S — Substrate	What physical and locational conditions structure the territory?	Terrain, coast, soils, resources, accessibility, exposure
T — Territorial trajectories	How did settlement and economic systems develop?	Urban expansion, industry, migration, land use, infrastructure
R — Regimes and institutions	Which rules and institutional investments became durable?	Boundaries, services, cadastres, property, welfare, governance
A — Actors and social morphology	Which groups, networks and memories organise local life?	Demography, occupations, associations, identities, oral history
T — Territorial political outputs	What political patterns are visible today?	Turnout, vote shares, protest, trust, policy conflict
A — Assessment and alternatives	How robust is the interpretation?	Controls, time comparison, field verification, uncertainty

3. Taranto as an urban electoral laboratory

The pilot applies the framework to Taranto's 2025 municipal election using 19 polling-place aggregates and 189 section-level runoff records. The city is treated as a multipolar urban system shaped by the historic Borgo, industrial and working-class districts, and the south-eastern residential expansion.

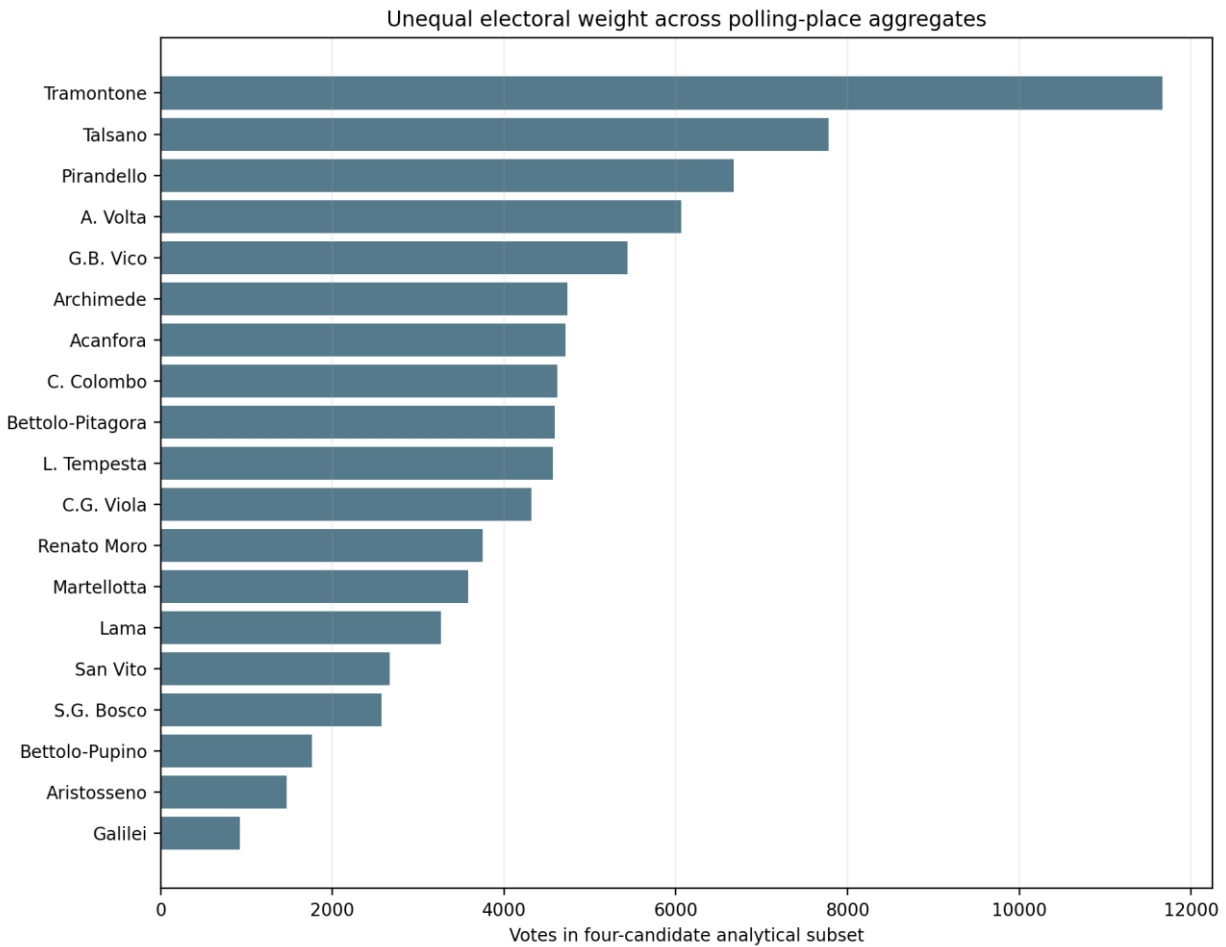


Analytical macro-areas used to interpret Taranto's dispersed urban structure.

Data caution

The workbook is a strong analytical pilot but requires final reconciliation against official election returns. First-round shares are presented within the analysed candidate set, while the runoff table contains a small aggregate discrepancy to be resolved before formal statistical publication.

4. The electoral centre of gravity moved south-east

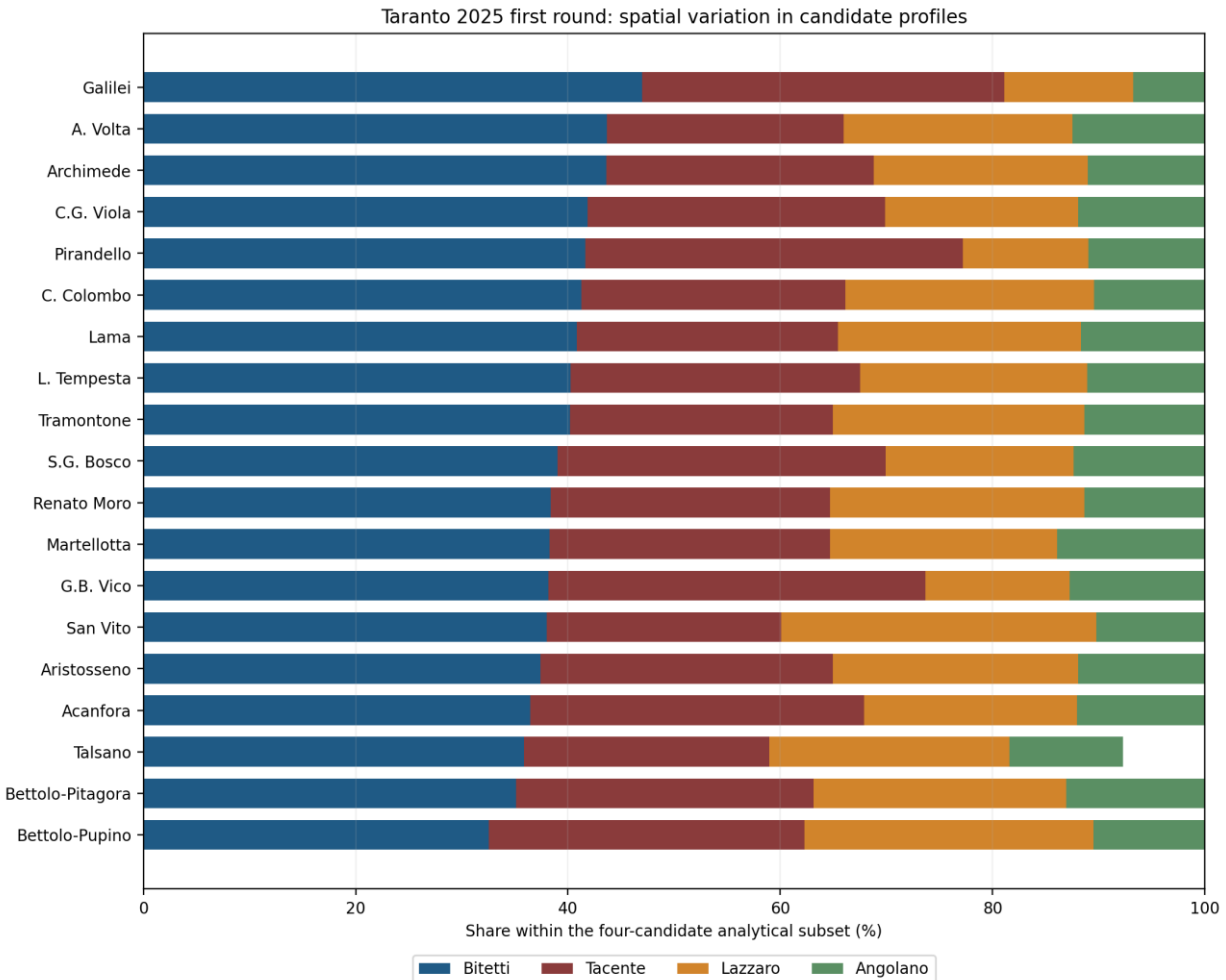


Electoral weight by polling-place aggregate highlights the growing importance of the south-eastern urban corridor.

The Taranto analysis suggests that the old political shorthand—elections being won primarily through the industrial-popular districts—no longer captures the distribution of active electoral weight. Talsano, Tramontone, Lama, San Vito, Taranto 2 and adjoining areas form a large and increasingly decisive electoral system.

The key strategic implication is not that southern districts possess a permanent political identity. It is that population, turnout, housing patterns and local institutional networks have shifted the places where campaigns must build sustained presence. Viale Magna Grecia emerges as a testable urban-political boundary rather than merely a road.

5. Candidate geographies reveal different coalitions

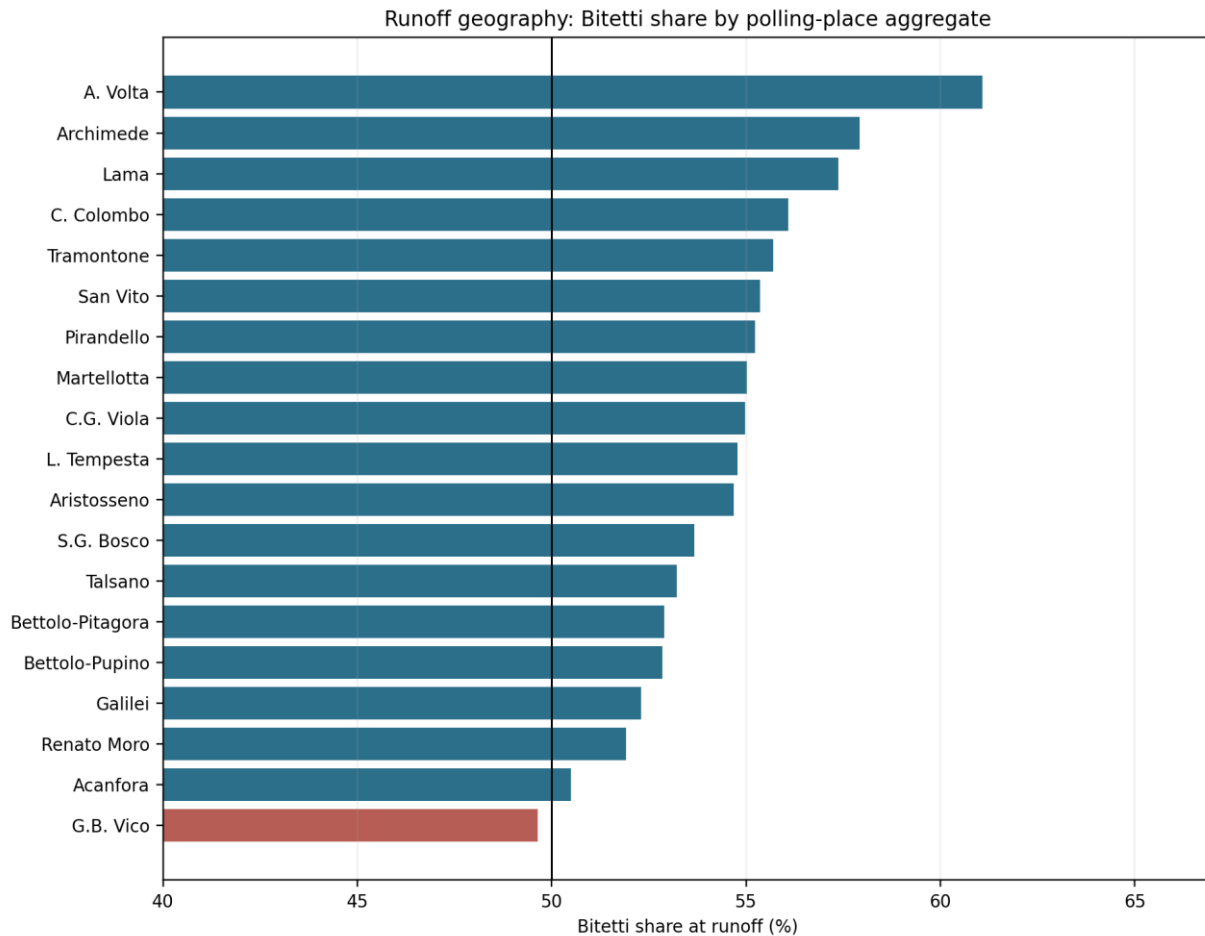


First-round profiles vary substantially across polling-place aggregates.

A single citywide percentage conceals distinct territorial coalitions. Bitetti's support was broad but especially strong in several south-eastern and modern residential aggregates. Tacente performed more strongly in parts of the consolidated city and in competitive central-popular areas. Lazzaro displayed a selective residential-managerial geography, including strong performances in San Vito and parts of the southern corridor. Angolano's support was lower overall but comparatively stronger in several mixed middle-class and dissent-oriented aggregates.

These are aggregate spatial associations, not individual voter profiles. They generate hypotheses for field research, message testing and institutional analysis.

6. The runoff: consolidation, competition and mobilisation



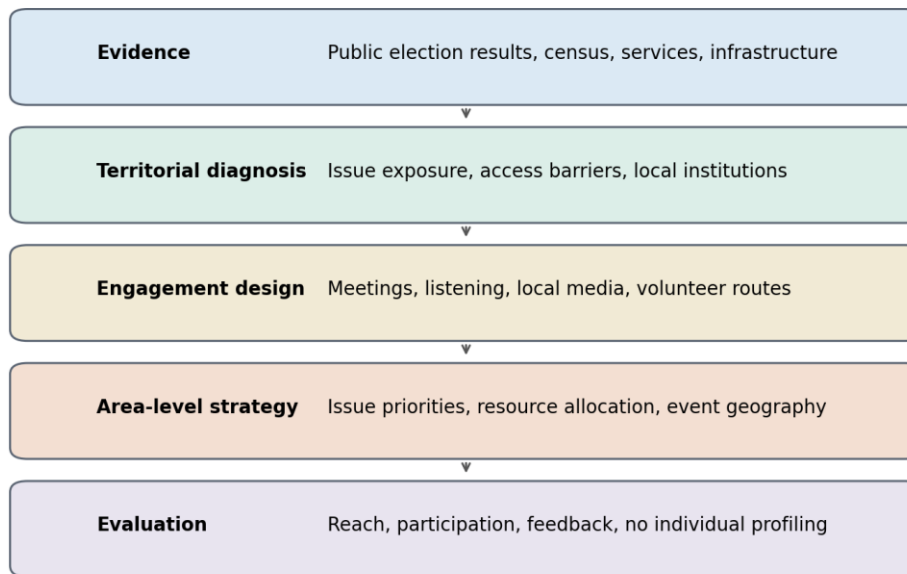
Runoff support for Bitetti across the 19 polling-place aggregates.

Across the section records in the working dataset, Bitetti receives 54.7% and Tacente 45.3%. The aggregate pattern is more useful than the citywide total: Alessandro Volta exceeds 60% for Bitetti, while G.B. Vico is effectively tied and Acanfora remains highly competitive.

A campaign atlas therefore separates stronghold consolidation from persuasion territories, turnout-recovery areas and zones requiring long-term listening. The first question is not “What message works everywhere?” but “What territorial problem and political relationship exist here?”

7. From maps to a neighbourhood campaign atlas

From territorial intelligence to an ethical neighbourhood campaign atlas



The campaign atlas converts territorial evidence into area-level strategic decisions.

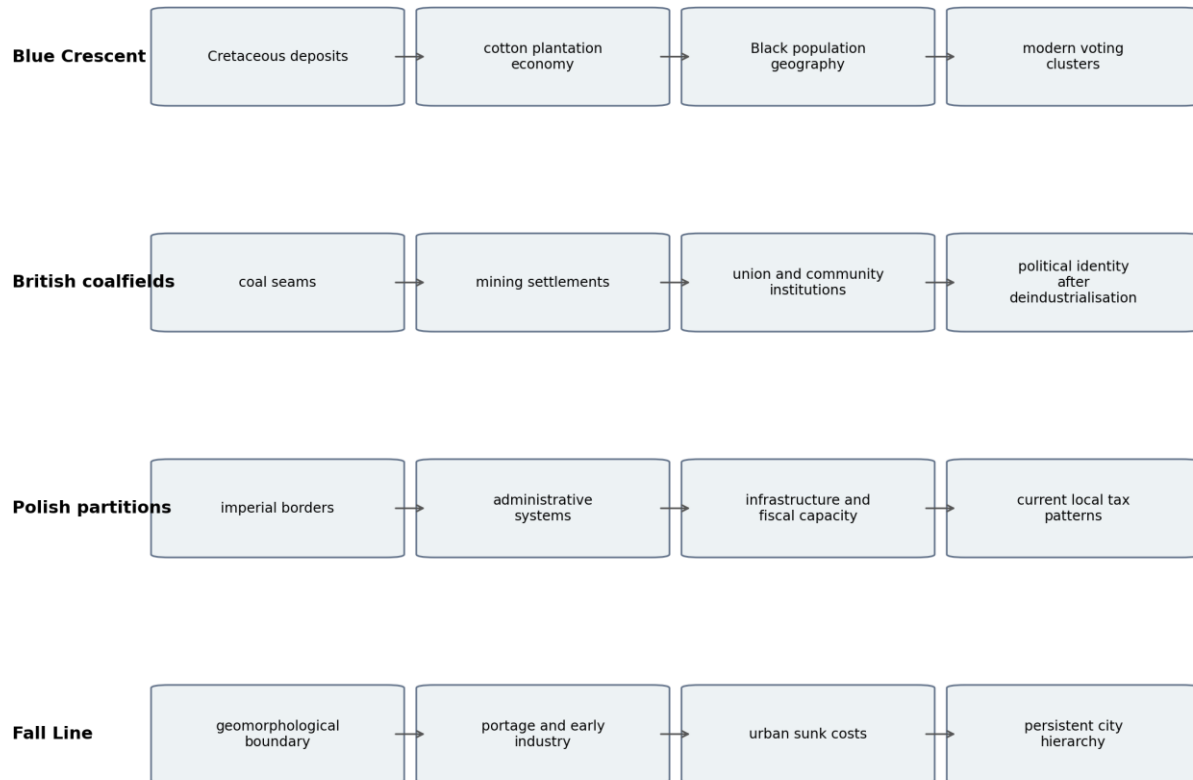
Territorial type	Primary objective	Appropriate action
High-weight stronghold	Consolidate and mobilise	Local organisers, turnout plan, service-delivery evidence, visible presence
High-weight competitive area	Persuade and listen	Issue-specific research, local validators, comparative message testing
Low-turnout or runoff-loss area	Re-mobilise	Barrier audit, contact-point mapping, event and volunteer accessibility
Candidate-specific pocket	Understand coalition structure	Interviews, network mapping, message and messenger analysis
Institutionally neglected area	Build long-term credibility	Permanent local partnerships, casework pathways, civic programme

Ethical boundary

The model supports neighbourhood-level strategy, not personalised political manipulation. It should not use private personal data, protected characteristics or inferred psychological vulnerabilities.

8. The long geography of politics

Mechanism chains in the comparative geo-historical atlas



Seven comparative cases test how geography becomes politically consequential through historical mechanisms.

The comparative atlas moves beyond election mapping to examine persistence. Its cases include the American South's Black Belt, British coalfields, Poland's historical partitions, the Eastern US Fall Line, extractive economies in Latin America, scarcity and conflict in Kenya's North Rift, and rural identity in the US Corn Belt.

The method explicitly rejects simple environmental determinism. Geology and physical geography affect political outcomes only through mechanisms such as economic specialisation, forced labour, settlement concentration, infrastructure, institutional capacity and identity formation. Each case therefore includes a causal chain, alternative explanations and an evidence-strength assessment.

9. The Political Territory Dossier

The operational product is a commissioned Political Territory Dossier. It can be delivered for a municipality, constituency, region, policy conflict or electoral campaign.

Module	Core output
Territorial baseline	Functional zones, settlement structure, infrastructure and demographic change
Electoral intelligence	Turnout, vote shares, competition, candidate concentration and temporal change
Historical mechanisms	Industrial legacies, boundaries, institutions, migration and collective memory
Actor ecosystem	Community organisations, institutions, professional networks and trusted intermediaries
Neighbourhood atlas	Area profiles, strategic typologies and priority questions
Field validation	Interviews, observation, local source review and hypothesis testing
Strategic scenarios	Aggregate campaign, public-affairs or governance options with risk assessment

10. Who can use it

- Think tanks: territorialise political trends, institutional trust and policy conflicts.
- Political teams: design differentiated neighbourhood strategies and field-research priorities.
- Public-affairs organisations: map stakeholder systems and local legitimacy.
- Municipalities: understand participation, service geographies and areas of political disconnection.
- Media and data-journalism teams: create evidence-based local political narratives.
- Foundations and international organisations: analyse governance, conflict, resilience and political inclusion.
- Civil-society organisations: identify participation barriers and strengthen place-based advocacy.

Competitive advantage

The method integrates GIS, electoral data, historical research and local qualitative evidence within a single workflow. It is designed to explain territorial mechanisms, not merely visualise results.

11. Quality, ethics and limitations

The principal methodological risk is ecological inference: aggregate results cannot establish how an individual or social group voted. Polling sections also imperfectly represent neighbourhoods, and comparisons across elections can be distorted by boundary changes, candidate supply and turnout.

Every dossier therefore includes a data audit, explicit uncertainty, temporal comparison, alternative explanations and field validation. Political uses should comply with applicable data-protection and electoral rules, remain transparent about data sources, and avoid suppression, intimidation or discriminatory targeting.

Safeguard	Operational rule
Aggregation	Work at polling-section, neighbourhood or larger territorial scale
Data minimisation	Use only data necessary for the research question
Protected characteristics	Do not infer or target individuals by sensitive attributes
Transparency	Document sources, calculations, assumptions and uncertainties
Validation	Test map patterns against history, institutions and field evidence
Review	Apply legal and ethical review before campaign deployment

12. Proposed next step

The next stage is to convert the Taranto pilot into a fully reconciled and geocoded demonstration dossier, then use it as the reference product for outreach to think tanks, political foundations, public-affairs organisations and data-driven campaign teams. The accompanying interactive atlases provide the public-facing demonstration layer, while the Technical and Data Appendix documents reproducibility.

Recommended pilot offer

A six-to-eight-week Political Territory Dossier combining data audit, GIS, historical reconstruction, stakeholder mapping, field interviews and a neighbourhood strategy workshop.

Companion outputs

- Main Research Report
- Taranto Interactive Electoral Atlas
- Global Geo-Historical Political Atlas
- Technical and Data Appendix
- Political Territory Dossier service sheet

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Core sources: Taranto 2025 working dataset and geographical essay; the Europe United Global Paleo-Political Laboratory; academic references listed in the Main Research Report.